

MOUNT KENYA UNIVERSITY
SCHOOL OF BUSINESS AND ECONOMICS

**INFLUENCE OF PUBLIC PARTICIPATION ON POLICY
IMPLEMENTATION IN MACHAKOS COUNTY GOVERNMENT,
KENYA**

[FULL NAME OF STUDENT]
[REGISTRATION NUMBER]

A Research Proposal Submitted to the School of Business and Economics in Partial
Fulfilment of the Requirements for the Award of the Degree of Master of Public
Administration of Mount Kenya University

SEPTEMBER 2026

DECLARATION

This research proposal is my original work and has not been presented for the award of a degree or for any other award in any other university.

Signature: _____ Date: _____

[Full Name of Student]

[Registration Number]

Supervisors' Approval

This research proposal has been submitted for examination with our approval as the university supervisors.

Signature: _____ Date: _____

[Name of Supervisor 1]

School of Business and Economics, Mount Kenya University

Signature: _____ Date: _____

[Name of Supervisor 2]

School of Business and Economics, Mount Kenya University

DEDICATION

I dedicate this work to my family for their patience, encouragement and unwavering support throughout my postgraduate studies, and to the residents of Machakos County, whose voices this study seeks to amplify.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I thank the Almighty God for the gift of life, good health and the strength to undertake this work. I am sincerely grateful to my supervisors for their guidance, constructive criticism and patience throughout the development of this proposal. I also appreciate the lecturers and staff of the School of Business and Economics at Mount Kenya University for the knowledge and support they have offered during my studies. My gratitude extends to my classmates for their encouragement and useful discussions, and to my family for standing with me at every stage. May God bless you all.

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ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS

CGM	County Government of Machakos
CIDP	County Integrated Development Plan
CoG	Council of Governors
CVI	Content Validity Index
KNBS	Kenya National Bureau of Statistics
MCA	Member of County Assembly
MKU	Mount Kenya University
NACOSTI	National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation
PFM	Public Finance Management
PMC	Project Management Committee
SMS	Short Message Service
SPSS	Statistical Package for the Social Sciences

OPERATIONAL DEFINITION OF TERMS

Public participation: The process through which residents of Machakos County, individually or through organised groups, take part in decisions and activities that shape how county policies are carried out. In this study it is measured through the level of involvement, the mechanisms used and the barriers experienced.

Policy implementation: The stage of the policy cycle at which approved county policies, programmes and projects are translated into services and physical outputs for residents.

Effectiveness of policy implementation: The degree to which a county policy is delivered on time, meets its stated targets, satisfies its intended beneficiaries and is owned and sustained by the community.

Participation mechanisms: The formal and informal channels through which the county invites and receives citizen input, including public barazas, ward development forums, sector working groups, project management committees and digital or SMS feedback platforms.

Barriers to participation: Structural, informational, economic and institutional factors that prevent residents from taking part meaningfully in implementation processes.

Co-production: An arrangement in which citizens act as active partners with public officials in designing, delivering and assessing public services, rather than as passive recipients.

Tokenism: A form of participation in which citizens are consulted or informed but have no real power to influence the final decision or its execution.

ABSTRACT

Kenya's 2010 Constitution promised citizens a real say in how they are governed, and devolution was meant to bring that promise closer to home. More than a decade later, many county policies still stall, run late or deliver less than was planned. Research on public participation in Kenya has mostly looked at planning and budgeting, and far less is known about what happens once a policy is approved and work begins on the ground. This study will examine how public participation influences policy implementation in the Machakos County Government. It will establish how far residents take part in implementing county policies, assess the channels the county uses to involve them, identify what stands in their way, and test whether higher participation goes hand in hand with better implementation. Arnstein's Ladder of Citizen Participation and the Theory of Co-production provide the theoretical lens. The study will use a descriptive cross-sectional survey supported by key informant interviews. It targets 514,059 residents of Machakos Town, Matungulu and Mwala sub-counties, which represent urban, peri-urban and rural settings, along with county officials involved in participation and service delivery. A sample of 400 residents will be drawn using Yamane's formula and proportionate stratified random sampling, and 29 key informants will be chosen purposively. A questionnaire and an interview guide, first pre-tested in Kathiani Sub-County, will be used to collect data. Quantitative data will be analysed in SPSS using descriptive statistics, correlation and regression, while interview data will be analysed thematically. The results should help the county government and other counties make participation count during implementation, and add Kenyan evidence to the study of devolved governance.

Key words: *public participation, policy implementation, devolution, co-production, county government, Machakos*

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background to the Study

Governments everywhere have learnt, sometimes at great cost, that policies made without the people they affect rarely work as intended. Citizen participation is therefore now treated as part of good public administration, and it carries practical weight as well as democratic value (Abas et al., 2023). When residents are involved, officials gain local knowledge they would otherwise lack. Policies fit real needs more closely, and communities are more willing to look after what is built for them (Loeffler & Bovaird, 2021). Few people dispute this in principle. The hard part is making it happen in the day-to-day work of government.

Experience in Europe shows how hard that can be. Studying Finnish local government, Jäntti et al. (2023) found that participation only takes root when it reaches the strategic, executive and frontline levels of an organisation; forums that sit apart from the offices making and carrying out decisions achieve little. A related study in Helsinki traced influential participation to three things: supportive structures, a receptive organisational culture and enough resources (Kurkela et al., 2024). Dutch residents interviewed by De Weger et al. (2022) wanted their involvement in municipal health policy to change something visible in their neighbourhoods, and said they needed clearer communication and easier processes if they were to stay involved. In Norway, Linstad et al. (2024) followed an inclusive eHealth governance model over ten years and showed that stakeholder buy-in during implementation had to be built steadily, and could just as easily be lost.

Whether participation actually improves outcomes is still debated. In Norwegian municipalities, efforts to widen participation did little for trust in local politicians and nothing measurable for turnout (Holum, 2023). Telling voters in Buenos Aires about a participatory budgeting programme nudged their opinion of government only slightly (Ardanaz et al., 2023), and a vignette experiment in South Korea found a similarly small effect (Campbell, 2023). None of this means participation is pointless. It suggests that people judge participation by its results, and that they need to see their input change what government does.

African decentralisation reforms have opened many new spaces for citizens, with mixed results. In Uganda, Mukiga et al. (2024) found that residents had little influence on local health services, partly because there was no functioning health committee through which to channel their views. In Mogadishu, on the other hand, residents who took part in local affairs trusted the city administration more, largely because they saw it as more

responsive (Abdi et al., 2025). The lesson from the continent is that participation can work, but only where the surrounding institutions allow it to.

Kenya is a useful case in this regard. Article 10(2)(a) of the Constitution of Kenya (2010) lists public participation among the national values of governance, and Article 174(c) names citizen empowerment as one of the objects of devolution. The County Governments Act (2012) and the Public Finance Management Act (2012) go further and require counties to build structures through which residents can shape plans and budgets. In 2023 the national government adopted the Kenya Policy on Public Participation as Sessional Paper No. 3 of 2023 to bring some consistency to practice (Republic of Kenya, 2023), and the Public Participation Bill, 2025 now seeks to set common standards in law (Republic of Kenya, 2025). The legal foundation, then, is solid. The open question is whether it gives citizens real influence once policies leave the drafting table.

County-level studies suggest it often does not. In Bungoma, participation improved governance and, through it, sustainable development (Hao et al., 2022). Kericho residents took part in budget meetings, public forums, record inspections and the election of project leaders, yet overall participation stayed low (Ngeno et al., 2023). Evidence from Laikipia and from a review of all 47 counties shows that the way a county communicates largely decides who turns up and who is left out (Wambugu et al., 2024; Wasike et al., 2024). At the national level, most Kenyans knew about the Finance Act, 2023, but very few took an active part in shaping it. Most of those surveyed felt that newspaper notices and public hearings did not reach ordinary people (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025).

Machakos County, which borders Nairobi to the east, shows these tensions clearly. The 2019 census counted 1,421,932 residents (Kenya National Bureau of Statistics [KNBS], 2019). They live in busy towns such as Machakos and Athi River, in fast-growing settlements along the roads into Nairobi, and in dry farming areas such as Mwala, Masinga and Yatta where rainfall is unreliable. Since 2013 the county has held ward budget meetings, sub-county development forums, sector working groups and public barazas, and it has recently added online and SMS feedback platforms. Its current development plan commits it to participatory planning and delivery in health, water, agriculture and roads (County Government of Machakos [CGM], 2023). Even so, when Mutua et al. (2024) studied water projects in Matungulu, they found that participation during planning clearly shaped how the projects turned out, but that residents were involved far less than the law expects. That gap between a well-designed participation system and the limited involvement residents actually experience is the starting point for this study.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

Under devolution, public participation is supposed to do more than gather opinions. Residents should help shape county policies, support their delivery and keep watch until the work is done. Where this happens, projects are more likely to be finished on time, to meet their goals and to be cared for by communities who see them as their own (Loeffler & Bovaird, 2021). This is the thinking behind the Constitution of Kenya (2010) and the County Governments Act (2012), and the Kenya Policy on Public Participation commits both levels of government to engagement that goes beyond a formality (Republic of Kenya, 2023).

The reality is less encouraging. County programmes are often delayed; some facilities are completed and then stand half-used; and many residents feel that forums are held to tick a legal box rather than to listen (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025; Ngeno et al., 2023). Machakos County's development plan commits the county to participatory delivery of its programmes (CGM, 2023). Yet in Matungulu, residents were far less involved in water projects than the law requires, and the projects suffered as a result (Mutua et al., 2024). If this pattern continues, public money will keep going into projects that residents did not prioritise, do not protect and may even resist, and confidence in devolution will weaken.

Kenyan research on participation has grown, but most of it looks at planning and budgeting or at a single sector such as water, health facilities or construction (Katumo & Odenyo, 2024; Malusha & Njoroge, 2023; Mutua et al., 2024). Some studies deal with national law-making rather than county delivery (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025), and others measure how counties communicate without asking what difference participation makes to results (Wambugu et al., 2024; Wasike et al., 2024). As things stand, there is little evidence on how much public participation affects the implementation of policies across sectors in Machakos County. The county cannot tell whether its participation structures are working or merely meeting a legal requirement, and residents cannot tell either. This study sets out to provide that evidence.

1.3 Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this study is to examine the influence of public participation on policy implementation in the Machakos County Government, Kenya, and to produce evidence the county can use to strengthen participation at the implementation stage.

1.4 Research Objectives

1.4.1 General Objective

The general objective of the study is to examine the influence of public participation on policy implementation in the Machakos County Government, Kenya.

1.4.2 Specific Objectives

The study will be guided by the following specific objectives:

- i. To establish the extent to which residents of Machakos County participate in the implementation of county government policies.
- ii. To assess the mechanisms used by the Machakos County Government to facilitate public participation in policy implementation.
- iii. To determine the challenges that hinder effective public participation in the implementation of county policies in Machakos County.
- iv. To examine the relationship between the level of public participation and the effectiveness of policy implementation in Machakos County.

1.5 Research Questions

The study will seek to answer the following questions:

- i. To what extent do residents of Machakos County participate in the implementation of county government policies?
- ii. What mechanisms does the Machakos County Government use to facilitate public participation in policy implementation?
- iii. What challenges hinder effective public participation in the implementation of county policies in Machakos County?
- iv. What is the relationship between the level of public participation and the effectiveness of policy implementation in Machakos County?

1.6 Research Hypothesis

The fourth objective will be addressed by testing the following null hypothesis at the 0.05 level of significance:

H₀₁: Public participation has no statistically significant influence on the effectiveness of policy implementation in the Machakos County Government.

1.7 Justification of the Study

The timing of this study is apt. With the Kenya Policy on Public Participation in place and the Public Participation Bill, 2025 before Parliament, the country is working out what good participation should look like (Republic of Kenya, 2023, 2025). A county that has run participatory structures for more than ten years has a good deal to teach that process, especially about the implementation stage, which national guidelines say relatively little about. The study also matters for public spending. Machakos directs much of its development budget to health, water, agriculture and roads (CGM, 2023), and in these sectors projects rarely succeed without local cooperation. Finally, scholars have urged researchers to stop counting meetings and start asking whether participation changes what governments actually do (Jäntti et al., 2023; Kurkela et al., 2024). This study takes up that call.

1.8 Significance of the Study

The Machakos County Government stands to gain most directly. The departments that handle public participation, finance and economic planning will learn which channels residents value and which they see as window dressing, and can use this to rethink how forums, feedback and project committees are run.

Other counties work under the same Constitution and face similar pressures, so the Council of Governors and individual county governments may find useful lessons here on linking citizen input to delivery. Those drafting national participation laws may also use the findings to set standards that cover feedback and follow-up, and not only the holding of hearings.

For residents and civil society groups in Machakos, the study offers a clearer view of how their involvement, or their absence, affects the services they receive. This may encourage them to stay engaged. For researchers in public administration and devolution, it adds evidence on the implementation stage, which Kenyan studies have so far touched on only lightly.

1.9 Limitations of the Study

Some residents may hesitate to criticise county officials or programmes openly, fearing that it could count against them. The researcher will guard against this by keeping questionnaires anonymous and explaining clearly that the study is purely academic. A second limitation is that residents' views of how well policies were implemented are perceptions and may not match official records. Where possible, their responses will be checked against county progress and budget implementation reports. Reaching respondents in the dry, scattered villages of Mwala may also be slow and costly.

Research assistants who know the area will be engaged, and visits will be timed around market days and local meetings, when people are easier to find.

1.10 Delimitations of the Study

The study is limited to the Machakos County Government and looks at participation in the implementation of county policies, not in their formulation. It covers three sub-counties: Machakos Town (urban), Matungulu (peri-urban) and Mwala (rural). Respondents will be residents aged 18 years and above, together with selected county officials. Only policies, programmes and projects implemented in the five years before data collection will be considered, which places them within the period of the current development plan (CGM, 2023).

1.11 Assumptions of the Study

The study assumes that respondents will answer honestly and accurately, and that residents of the selected sub-counties have had some contact with county implementation activities during the reference period. It further assumes that county officials will make time for interviews and allow access to relevant documents, and that the three sampled sub-counties broadly reflect the range of participation experiences across the county.

CHAPTER TWO

LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction

This chapter reviews the literature on public participation and policy implementation. It opens with the two theories on which the study rests and then reviews empirical studies under each of the four specific objectives. The conceptual framework follows, together with a critique of the literature and a summary of the gaps this study aims to fill.

2.2 Theoretical Review

Two theories guide the study. Arnstein's Ladder of Citizen Participation helps to judge how much real influence citizens have, while the Theory of Co-production explains why their involvement matters for delivering public services and policies.

2.2.1 Ladder of Citizen Participation

Arnstein (1969) argued that citizen participation is, at heart, a question of who holds power. She described eight rungs arranged in three bands. At the bottom, manipulation and therapy amount to non-participation. The middle band, made up of informing, consultation and placation, is what she called tokenism: citizens are allowed to speak, but they cannot make sure anyone acts on what they say. Only at the top, through partnership, delegated power and citizen control, do citizens hold real power. Arnstein's main point was that participation without any shift in power is an empty ritual. It lets those in authority claim that everyone was consulted while decisions continue to favour a few.

The ladder is still widely used because it gives a simple way to judge how deep participation goes, beyond whether it happened at all (Abas et al., 2023). Critics say it treats participation as a single climb in which more control is always better, when in fact citizens may want different kinds of involvement for different issues (De Weger et al., 2022). It also has little to say about the institutions needed to move up the rungs. Even with these weaknesses, the ladder suits this study well. Kenyan law uses the language of the upper rungs, while research keeps finding that practice stops somewhere around informing and consultation (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025; Ngeno et al., 2023). The theory therefore informs the first and second objectives, giving the study a yardstick for how deeply residents take part and a way of classifying the channels the county uses.

2.2.2 Theory of Co-production

The idea of co-production is closely linked to Ostrom (1996). She observed that many public services depend on effort from both officials and the citizens who use them. A

school needs pupils and parents as much as teachers, and a water scheme needs users who pay, report leaks and protect the pipes. Co-production works best when what government and citizens bring to a service complement each other, and when rules and institutions make that cooperation possible. Later writers have broken co-production into four activities: co-commissioning, co-design, co-delivery and co-assessment of services (Loeffler & Bovaird, 2021).

The theory has its critics. It can shift extra work onto citizens, especially poorer ones who have little spare time or money, and it can blur who is accountable when things go wrong (Loeffler & Bovaird, 2021). Its value for this study is that it carries the discussion past decision-making and into delivery. It implies that county policies will be better implemented when residents help monitor projects, share local knowledge and protect finished facilities. The theory therefore underpins the third and fourth objectives. It explains why obstacles to participation should weaken implementation, and why more participation should go with better results.

2.3 Empirical Review

The empirical studies are reviewed below under each of the four specific objectives.

2.3.1 Extent of Public Participation in Policy Implementation

Kenyan studies suggest that participation in county affairs takes many forms but seldom goes very deep. Using a concurrent mixed-methods design in Kericho County, Ngeno et al. (2023) found residents involved in budget preparation, public forums, scrutiny of records, the election of project leaders and seminars. Across all of these, however, participation was low. Their study was confined to development projects and did not ask how participation affected outcomes, which is one of the questions the present study will take up.

Closer to home, Mutua et al. (2024) surveyed 220 household heads in Matungulu Sub-County and also spoke to a water project manager and eight members of water user committees. Participation during planning had a significant effect on how the water projects turned out, but actual involvement fell well short of what the law envisages. Because the study dealt only with the planning of water projects, it does not show how residents take part once policies in other sectors are being carried out.

The national picture is similar. Maiyo and Kinuthia (2025) collected views from 86 citizens, civil society members and policy makers and found that, although many people knew about the Finance Act, 2023, few took an active part in it. Reviewing ten years of research on participation in local planning, Abas et al. (2023) concluded that participation tends to be concentrated in the early stages of decision-making and rarely

carries through to delivery. These findings lead the researcher to expect modest levels of participation in implementation in Machakos, an expectation the study will test.

2.3.2 Mechanisms for Facilitating Public Participation

How a county invites people to take part has a lot to do with who shows up. In Laikipia County, Wambugu et al. (2024) found that the way information was communicated made a significant difference to participation, and that face-to-face contact and SMS messages were the most effective ways of getting people to meetings. Looking across all 47 counties, Wasike et al. (2024) found that the reach and success of county communication approaches varied a great deal. In the case of the Finance Act, 2023, newspaper adverts, written memoranda and public hearings were the main channels used, yet almost all respondents felt they did not reach most of the population (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025).

Online channels are often put forward as a way to widen access. In their review of e-participation research, Benlahcene et al. (2024) found that digital platforms make taking part more convenient, but citizens face hurdles such as weak digital skills, poor connectivity and doubts about what happens to their contributions. De Weger et al. (2022) noted that Dutch residents engaged more readily when municipalities used plain language and explained how input would be used. In Norway, a formal stakeholder board served as a standing channel for aligning interests throughout implementation (Linstad et al., 2024). Most of these studies look at how mechanisms are designed and how far they reach. Very few ask whether a particular mechanism leads to better implementation at county level, and this study intends to do so.

2.3.3 Challenges Hindering Effective Public Participation

Researchers have identified many obstacles to effective participation. In Bungoma County, Hao et al. (2022) used structural equation modelling and found that several challenges limited how far participation was integrated into governance and, with it, how much it contributed to sustainable development. Interviews with 14 key actors in Helsinki led Kurkela et al. (2024) to conclude that structures, culture and resources determine whether participation has influence, so a shortfall in any one of them becomes a barrier. Jäntti et al. (2023) added that participation falters when citizens' views are gathered in one part of an organisation and never reach the units that carry out the work.

In Uganda, Mukiga et al. (2024) interviewed 66 people, among them health workers, residents, local councillors and administrators. With no active health committee in place, residents had no formal way to influence how local health services were run. Other studies point to the digital divide (Benlahcene et al., 2024) and to short notice and

hard-to-reach venues (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025). These studies are useful, but they come from different places and sectors. Nobody has yet mapped the particular mix of barriers faced by Machakos residents, who live in urban, peri-urban and rural settings within one county.

2.3.4 Public Participation and Effectiveness of Policy Implementation

A number of studies have linked participation to implementation. In neighbouring Makueni County, well known for its participatory budgeting, Katumo and Odenyo (2024) found that citizen involvement was associated with the implementation of county projects. Malusha and Njoroge (2023), working from participatory democracy theory, examined how informing, consultation, collaboration and empowerment affected the implementation of the County Integrated Development Plan in Voi Sub-County, Taita Taveta. In Matungulu, participation in planning water projects significantly influenced how well those projects performed (Mutua et al., 2024).

Studies from other countries add a note of caution. In Mogadishu, Abdi et al. (2025) surveyed 446 residents and found that participation raised trust in local government, partly because it made the administration appear more responsive. Yet in Norway, government efforts to widen participation barely affected trust (Holum, 2023), and studies in Argentina and South Korea found only small gains in trust from learning about or experiencing participatory processes (Ardanaz et al., 2023; Campbell, 2023). What emerges is that participation improves results mainly when citizens can see their input making a difference. Most Kenyan studies have looked at one sector or at the planning stage. This study will examine the relationship across sectors and at the implementation stage in Machakos County.

2.4 Conceptual Framework

Figure 2.1 sets out the expected relationship between public participation, the independent variable, and the effectiveness of policy implementation, the dependent variable. Drawing on the specific objectives, participation is measured along three dimensions: how much residents take part, the mechanisms through which they do so and the barriers they encounter. Implementation effectiveness is judged by whether programmes are delivered on time, whether they meet their targets, whether beneficiaries are satisfied and whether communities take ownership of what is delivered. The county's institutional capacity, political goodwill and available budget are treated as intervening variables that may strengthen or weaken the relationship.

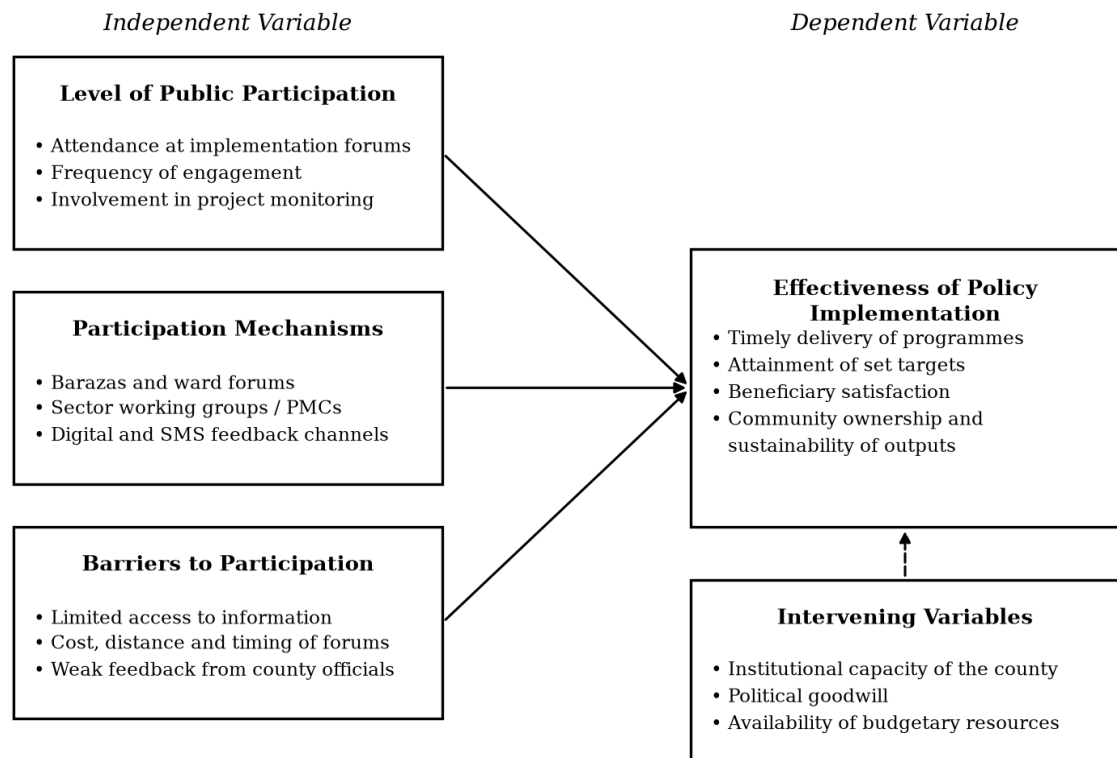


Figure 2.1: Conceptual Framework

Source: Researcher (2026)

2.5 Critique of Existing Literature

The literature reviewed has some clear weaknesses. Many Kenyan studies look at participation during planning or budgeting and simply assume that its benefits carry over into implementation (Malusha & Njoroge, 2023; Mutua et al., 2024). That assumption is rarely tested. Several studies also rest on small samples or a single sector, such as water projects or health facilities, so it is hard to say whether their findings apply to the full range of a county's work (Katumo & Odenyo, 2024; Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025). Research on mechanisms, meanwhile, tends to count attendance. It tells us who came to a forum but not whether the forum changed anything (Wambugu et al., 2024; Wasike et al., 2024). International studies go further into organisational and trust issues (Holum, 2023; Kurkela et al., 2024), but they come from countries with stronger institutions and far more resources than Kenyan counties. This study responds by combining a survey across sectors with interviews of officials, and by focusing squarely on implementation.

2.6 Summary of Literature and Research Gaps

The studies reviewed agree that public participation matters for governance and service delivery. They also show that participation in Kenyan counties is often low, that the channels used reach limited sections of the population, and that institutional,

informational and economic barriers keep many residents out. Table 2.1 summarises the main studies and the gaps this study seeks to address.

Table 2.1: Summary of Research Gaps

Author(s)	Focus of Study	Key Findings	Knowledge Gap
Mutua et al. (2024)	Planning-phase participation and water project outcomes, Matungulu	Participation significantly influenced outcomes, but levels were low	Focused on planning and one sector; this study covers implementation across sectors
Ngeno et al. (2023)	Modes of participation, Kericho County	Participation across all modes was low	Did not link participation to outcomes; this study tests the relationship
Maiyo & Kinuthia (2025)	Participation in the Finance Act, 2023	Channels used were judged ineffective by most respondents	National legislative focus; this study examines county implementation
Katumo & Odenyo (2024)	Participation and county project implementation, Makueni	Citizen involvement associated with project implementation	Different county context; this study focuses on Machakos
Wambugu et al. (2024)	Communication modes and participation, Laikipia	Face-to-face and SMS most effective for mobilisation	Measured attendance, not influence on implementation
Kurkela et al. (2024)	Organisational prerequisites for participation, Helsinki	Structures, culture and resources determine influence	High-capacity European setting; this study examines a Kenyan county

Source: Researcher (2026)

CHAPTER THREE

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter explains how the study will be carried out. It describes the research design, study location, target population, sampling techniques and sample size, research instruments, pilot testing, validity and reliability, data collection procedures, data analysis and ethical considerations.

3.2 Research Design

The study will use a descriptive cross-sectional survey design supported by key informant interviews. A descriptive design allows a researcher to describe a population and examine relationships between variables as they occur naturally, without manipulating anything (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). Data will be collected at a single point in time, which suits the time and budget available. The survey will measure how much residents participate and how this relates to implementation. The interviews will help explain the patterns that emerge, in keeping with a convergent mixed-methods approach (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). Similar designs have worked well in recent Kenyan studies on the subject (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025; Mutua et al., 2024).

3.3 Location of the Study

The study will take place in Machakos County, one of the 47 counties created under the Constitution of Kenya (2010). Covering roughly 6,000 square kilometres, the county borders Nairobi, Kiambu, Murang'a, Embu, Kitui, Makueni and Kajiado. Its population stood at 1,421,932 in the 2019 census (KNBS, 2019). Machakos was chosen for several reasons. Within one county it combines busy towns, peri-urban settlements growing along the Nairobi corridor and dry rural areas, so residents' experiences of participation are likely to vary. The county has also used ward forums, sector working groups and digital platforms since 2013 (CGM, 2023), so there is an established system to study. In addition, earlier work in Matungulu has already pointed to a gap between what the law requires and what residents actually experience (Mutua et al., 2024). The study will focus on Machakos Town Sub-County (urban), Matungulu Sub-County (peri-urban) and Mwala Sub-County (rural).

3.4 Target Population

The study targets two groups. The first is the residents of the three selected sub-counties, 514,059 people according to the 2019 census (KNBS, 2019). The second is county officials who work directly on public participation and policy implementation.

These include the three sub-county administrators, the 18 ward administrators in the selected sub-counties, and officers from the departments responsible for public participation and civic education, finance and economic planning, health, and water. Table 3.1 shows how the resident population is distributed.

Table 3.1: Target Population of Residents

Sub-County	Setting	Population (2019)	Percentage
Machakos Town	Urban	170,606	33.2
Matungulu	Peri-urban	161,557	31.4
Mwala	Rural	181,896	35.4
Total		514,059	100.0

Source: KNBS (2019)

3.5 Sampling Techniques and Sample Size

3.5.1 Sampling Techniques

Sampling will be done in stages. The three sub-counties have been picked purposively to cover urban, peri-urban and rural settings, since access to participation opportunities is likely to differ across them (Wambugu et al., 2024). The resident sample will then be shared among the sub-counties in proportion to their populations. Within each ward, households will be selected by simple random sampling using ward registers and village maps, with help from village administrators, and one adult will be interviewed in each household. Key informants will be chosen purposively because of what they know about how participation is organised and how county policies are carried out (Saunders et al., 2023).

3.5.2 Sample Size

The resident sample size will be calculated using Yamane's (1967) formula for a finite population, at a 95% confidence level and a 5% margin of error:

$$n = N / (1 + N e^2)$$

Here n is the sample size, N is the target population (514,059) and e is the margin of error (0.05). This gives $n = 514,059 / (1 + 514,059 \times 0.0025) = 399.7$, rounded to 400 respondents. Table 3.2 shows how the sample is spread across the sub-counties, and Table 3.3 lists the key informants.

Table 3.2: Sample Size Distribution of Residents

Sub-County	Population	Proportion	Sample Size
Machakos Town	170,606	0.332	133
Matungulu	161,557	0.314	126

Sub-County	Population	Proportion	Sample Size
Mwala	181,896	0.354	141
Total	514,059	1.000	400

Source: Researcher (2026)

Table 3.3: Sample of Key Informants

Category	Number	Sampling Technique
Sub-county administrators	3	Census
Ward administrators	18	Census
Departmental officers (public participation, finance and economic planning, health, water)	8	Purposive (2 per department)
Total	29	

Source: Researcher (2026)

In total, 429 people will take part in the study: 400 residents and 29 key informants.

3.6 Research Instruments

Two instruments will be used. Residents will complete a structured questionnaire in five parts: background information, extent of participation, participation mechanisms, challenges to participation and effectiveness of policy implementation. Most items use a five-point Likert scale from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree), and a few open questions give respondents room to raise issues the researcher may not have anticipated. The questionnaire will be translated into Kiswahili and Kikamba and then translated back into English to confirm that the meaning has not shifted. Key informants will be interviewed using a semi-structured guide covering how participation is organised, how residents' input is used during implementation and what constraints the county faces. County documents, including annual development plans, budget implementation reports and public participation reports, will also be reviewed so that findings can be cross-checked.

Table 3.4: Operationalisation of Study Variables

Variable	Type	Indicators	Measurement
Level of public participation	Independent	Attendance at forums; frequency of engagement; involvement in monitoring	Five-point Likert scale
Participation mechanisms	Independent	Barazas; ward forums; sector working groups; PMCs; digital and SMS channels	Five-point Likert scale
Barriers to participation	Independent	Access to information; cost and distance; timing; feedback from officials	Five-point Likert scale

Variable	Type	Indicators	Measurement
Effectiveness of policy implementation	Dependent	Timeliness; target attainment; beneficiary satisfaction; ownership and sustainability	Five-point Likert scale

Source: Researcher (2026)

3.7 Pilot Testing

Before the main study, the instruments will be tried out in Kathiani Sub-County, which is similar to the study area but will not be part of the main sample. The pilot will involve 40 residents, equal to 10% of the main sample, and three key informants. It will show which questions are unclear, how long the questionnaire takes, and whether the scales are reliable. Any items that cause difficulty will be revised before the main fieldwork.

3.7.1 Validity of Research Instruments

Validity is the extent to which an instrument measures what it is meant to measure (Saunders et al., 2023). To establish content validity, every item will be matched to a study objective and to the conceptual framework. The university supervisors and two experts in public administration will then review the instruments and rate how relevant each item is. From their ratings a Content Validity Index (CVI) will be calculated, and a value of 0.80 or higher will be taken as acceptable. The pilot study will help to confirm face validity.

3.7.2 Reliability of Research Instruments

Reliability refers to whether an instrument gives consistent results under similar conditions (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). Cronbach's alpha will be calculated from the pilot data to check the internal consistency of each Likert scale. A coefficient of 0.70 or above will be accepted, and any item that pulls a scale below this level will be revised or dropped. For the interviews, trustworthiness will be supported by cross-checking against documents, keeping careful notes, recording interviews where consent is given, and keeping a record of analytical decisions (Braun & Clarke, 2022).

3.8 Data Collection Procedures

Once the proposal is approved, the researcher will obtain an introduction letter from Mount Kenya University, ethical clearance from the university's ethics review committee and a research permit from the National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation (NACOSTI). Permission will also be sought from the Machakos County Government and the County Commissioner. Six research assistants from the study area who speak Kikamba and Kiswahili will receive two days of training on the instruments, sampling and research ethics. They will administer the

questionnaires face to face and read the questions aloud for respondents who prefer it. The researcher will conduct all key informant interviews in person, at times that suit the officials. Completed questionnaires will be checked each evening for missing or inconsistent answers.

3.9 Data Analysis and Presentation

Quantitative data will be cleaned, coded and entered into the Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS) version 29. The first three objectives will be addressed using descriptive statistics: frequencies, percentages, means and standard deviations. For the fourth objective, Pearson's correlation will show the strength and direction of the relationship between public participation and implementation effectiveness, and simple linear regression will then be used to test the null hypothesis with the following model:

$$Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X + \varepsilon$$

In this model, Y is the effectiveness of policy implementation, β_0 is the constant, β_1 is the coefficient of public participation, X is the composite public participation index and ε is the error term. To see how much each dimension contributes on its own, a supplementary multiple regression model will also be fitted:

$$Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X_1 + \beta_2 X_2 + \beta_3 X_3 + \varepsilon$$

Here X_1 is the level of participation, X_2 is the adequacy of participation mechanisms and X_3 is the severity of barriers to participation. Before running the regressions, the researcher will check the assumptions of normality, linearity, homoscedasticity and absence of multicollinearity. The null hypothesis will be rejected if the p-value is below 0.05. Interview recordings and answers to open-ended questions will be transcribed, coded and analysed thematically using the six phases set out by Braun and Clarke (2022). Results will be presented in tables, figures and narrative, with direct quotations used to bring out the main themes.

3.10 Ethical Considerations

The study will follow accepted ethical standards for research with human participants. Approval will be obtained from the Mount Kenya University ethics review committee, and a research permit from NACOSTI. Taking part will be voluntary. Each respondent will have the purpose, procedures, risks and benefits of the study explained before being asked for informed consent, and anyone may skip a question or withdraw at any point without penalty. Questionnaires will carry no names or identifying details, and interview transcripts will use codes in place of names. Data will be kept in password-protected files that only the researcher and supervisors can open, and will be used for

academic purposes alone. All sources will be properly acknowledged. A short, plain-language summary of the findings will be shared with the county government and the communities that took part.

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APPENDICES

Appendix I: Letter of Introduction

Dear Respondent,

RE: REQUEST TO PARTICIPATE IN A RESEARCH STUDY

I am a postgraduate student at Mount Kenya University, School of Business and Economics, pursuing a Master's degree in Public Administration. I am conducting a study entitled "Influence of Public Participation on Policy Implementation in Machakos County Government, Kenya" in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of the degree.

You have been selected to take part in this study. Kindly spare about 20 minutes to respond to the attached questionnaire. The information you provide will be treated with strict confidentiality and will be used only for academic purposes. Your name will not appear anywhere in the report.

Thank you for your time and cooperation.

Yours faithfully,

[Student Name]

Reg. No. [Registration Number]

Appendix II: Informed Consent Form

I have been informed of the purpose of this study, the procedures involved, and my right to decline any question or to withdraw at any time without any consequence. I understand that my responses will be kept confidential and used solely for academic purposes. I therefore voluntarily agree to take part in this study.

Signature/Thumbprint of respondent: _____ Date: _____

Signature of researcher: _____ Date: _____

Appendix III: Questionnaire for Residents

Instructions: Please tick (✓) the appropriate box or write your answer in the space provided. Do not write your name on this questionnaire.

Section A: Demographic Information

1. Gender: Male ☐ Female ☐
2. Age bracket (years): 18–25 ☐ 26–35 ☐ 36–45 ☐ 46–55 ☐ Above 55 ☐
3. Highest level of education: None ☐ Primary ☐ Secondary ☐ College ☐ University ☐
4. Sub-County of residence: Machakos Town ☐ Matungulu ☐ Mwala ☐
5. Length of residence in the ward: Below 2 years ☐ 2–5 years ☐ 6–10 years ☐ Above 10 years ☐
6. Main occupation: Farming ☐ Business ☐ Formal employment ☐ Casual work ☐ Other ☐

Section B: Extent of Public Participation in Policy Implementation

Key: 1 = Strongly Disagree; 2 = Disagree; 3 = Neutral; 4 = Agree; 5 = Strongly Agree

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
7	I have attended at least one county forum on the implementation of a county project or programme in the last two years.					
8	I am regularly informed about county projects being implemented in my ward.					
9	I have been involved in monitoring the progress of a county project in my area.					
10	Residents in my ward are consulted when changes are made to projects during implementation.					
11	My views have influenced how a county project was carried out in my area.					
12	Residents are represented in project management committees in my ward.					

Section C: Mechanisms for Facilitating Public Participation

Key: 1 = Strongly Disagree; 2 = Disagree; 3 = Neutral; 4 = Agree; 5 = Strongly Agree

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
13	Public barazas are an effective way for residents to give views on county projects.					
14	Ward development forums give residents a real opportunity to influence implementation.					
15	Sector working groups (e.g. health, water, agriculture) involve ordinary residents.					
16	Project management committees effectively represent community interests.					
17	The county's online and SMS platforms make it easy for me to give feedback.					
18	Notices of public participation forums are communicated in good time and in a language I understand.					

Section D: Challenges Hindering Public Participation

Key: 1 = Strongly Disagree; 2 = Disagree; 3 = Neutral; 4 = Agree; 5 = Strongly Agree

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
19	I lack adequate information about county policies and projects.					
20	Forums are held at times that are inconvenient for me.					
21	The cost of travelling to forum venues discourages me from attending.					
22	County officials rarely give feedback on how residents' views were used.					
23	Participation forums are dominated by political or elite interests.					
24	Women, youth and persons with disabilities face extra difficulties in participating.					

Section E: Effectiveness of Policy Implementation

Key: 1 = Strongly Disagree; 2 = Disagree; 3 = Neutral; 4 = Agree; 5 = Strongly Agree

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
25	County projects in my ward are completed within the planned time.					

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
26	County projects in my ward achieve the targets they were designed for.					
27	I am satisfied with the services delivered through county projects in my ward.					
28	Residents in my ward take care of and protect completed county projects.					
29	County projects in my ward address the priorities raised by residents.					
30	Completed county projects in my ward continue to function well over time.					

Section F: General Comments

31. In your opinion, what should the Machakos County Government do to improve public participation in the implementation of its policies and projects?

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Thank you for your participation.

Appendix IV: Interview Guide for Key Informants

Introduction: The researcher will give a brief self-introduction, explain the purpose of the study, assure the respondent of confidentiality, and seek consent to take notes and record the interview.

1. Please describe your role in public participation and the implementation of county policies.
2. How does the county involve residents once a policy, programme or project has been approved for implementation?
3. Which participation mechanisms have been most effective in your area, and why?
4. How is the feedback received from residents used during implementation? Could you give an example?
5. What challenges does the county face in facilitating public participation during implementation?
6. What challenges do residents face in taking part in implementation processes?
7. In your experience, how has public participation affected the timeliness, quality and sustainability of county projects?
8. How do institutional capacity, political goodwill and budgetary resources affect participation in implementation?
9. What measures would you recommend to strengthen public participation in policy implementation in Machakos County?

Appendix V: Work Plan

Activity	Timeline
Development and approval of the research proposal	Oct – Dec 2026
Proposal defence and corrections	Jan 2027
Ethical clearance and NACOSTI research permit	Feb 2027
Pilot testing and refinement of instruments	Feb 2027
Field data collection	Mar – Apr 2027
Data analysis and interpretation	May 2027
Thesis writing and submission to supervisors	Jun – Jul 2027
Thesis defence, corrections and final submission	Aug 2027

Appendix VI: Research Budget

Budget Item	Estimated Cost (KES)
Literature and reference materials	10,000
Training and remuneration of 6 research assistants	48,000
Transport and logistics within Machakos County	30,000
Printing, photocopying and questionnaire reproduction	15,000
Translation of instruments (Kiswahili and Kikamba)	6,000
Communication and airtime	5,000
Data analysis software and services	15,000
Ethical review and NACOSTI permit fees	6,000
Thesis printing, binding and dissemination	10,000
Subtotal	145,000
Contingency (10%)	14,500
Total	159,500